



An i-Shakti kiosk set up in the owner's house

a particular section such as health or employment right from the kiosk in his village.

The i-Shakti system is designed as an easy to use, "talking" voice-based system in Telugu, the state language. All information on various topics is in the form of audio or video, and the user does not necessarily have to read off the screen. The graphical user interfaces are designed such that icons speak when a mouse is scrolled over them. Once a user knows what area he wants information on, he can click the relevant icon for further information.

For example, on the Agriculture icon, there are subsections titled Wheat, Paddy, Cotton, and so on. Once a user scrolls over an image of, say, cotton, a voice announces the name of the crop in Telugu. He can then click on

the Cotton icon to access information on types of cotton, seasons for growth, pest control, fertilisers, and so on.

"We have avoided making the Internet available to the villagers to keep costs down. The Net is only used to synchronise data and mail it to the office in Mumbai. We monitor each and every bit of information that is passed back and forth and between user, expert and kiosk owner. Even this data comes in during the synchronisation. Hence, we can keep a tab on everything from our office in Mumbai and run things efficiently," says Marolli.

How each member uses the data is also tracked and recorded. The system is constantly monitored for the most frequently-visited sections and the duration



of the visits. Based on usage, there is a lucky draw each month for the person who uses the system most efficiently. Besides, relevant offers and rewards are given to other users who use the system effectively. For example, if a member visits the Education section regularly, he might be offered a discount on stationery or books. This offer directly appears on the computer screen when the user logs in, and this system encourages members to use the system. Besides, the fact that the information is free is an incentive by itself.

In less than six months since i-Shakti's launch in September 2005, the network has grown to about 970 kiosks in 21 districts in Andhra Pradesh, with a registered customer base of 1.5 lakh users.

One of the kiosk owners, Shantamma, says, "The programme has created a stir ever since it began. We have people from all age groups using the system. Practically all are registered users, and we have six to seven users coming in every day."

"The system is designed such that it can be set up and configured for use in different languages. The groundwork has been laid to take the initiative forward," says Marolli.

The people of Nallagonda, AP, where the first kiosk was set up, are not unaware of the opportunity that is at their doorstep today. Provided with resources, these people are apt to make the best use of them. ■

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